Better forecasts, not yet better captains

Forecasting Fantasy Premier League points: a three-season walk-forward test

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In short. We forecast every player's Fantasy Premier League points with gradient-boosted trees and tested them week by week on 114 gameweeks they had not seen, across every registered player. The forecasts are clearly more accurate than recent form or a simple regression. The decisions they lead to are less clearly better. The model's captains beat a "priciest attacker" rule, but not a form rule that accounts for double gameweeks. They also trail the captain chosen most often by each season's eventual top-100 managers by 1.59 points a week. Basketball's "usage rate", adapted to football, barely helped.

The question

Every week, Fantasy Premier League (FPL) managers pick eleven starters and a captain whose points are doubled (Fantasy Premier League, 2026b). Several studies forecast FPL points (Frees et al., 2024; Gupta, 2019; Lombu et al., 2024; Ramezani and Dinh, 2025), mostly judged by forecast error. We ask whether a forecast leads to better weekly *decisions* than the rules and consensus managers already use.

How we tested it

- **Data.** Every registered player, every gameweek, 2022/23–2025/26 (113,042 player-weeks), including players who never played (Fantasy Premier League, 2026a).
- **Model.** Gradient-boosted trees (Friedman, 2001) on 32 inputs: recent minutes and form, per-90 xG and xA, season and prior-season rates, and club and opponent strength from xG (Dixon and Coles, 1997; Maher, 1982).
- **No peeking.** Each week is forecast by a model retrained only on earlier weeks (Tashman, 2000).
- **Comparators.** The priciest attacker who played last week; the best recent form; form scaled by the coming week's fixture count; a ridge regression; and the top-100 managers' consensus captain.
- **A rule set in advance.** To pass, the model's weekly advantage over every original comparator needed a 95% interval above zero (Efron and Tibshirani, 1993; Nosek et al., 2018).

What we found

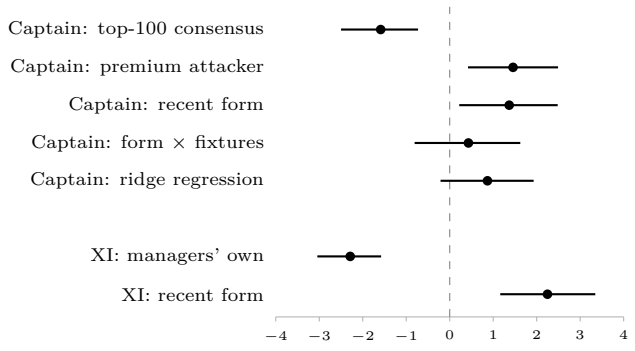


Figure 1: Model minus comparator, points per gameweek, with 95% intervals over 114 gameweeks. Right of zero favours the model. XI comparisons use the top-100 managers' real squads.

	Error (MAE)	Weekly rank*
Model	0.996	0.31
Ridge regression	1.046	0.28
Recent form × fixtures	1.053	0.21

Table 1: Accuracy over 84,200 player-weeks. *Within-week rank correlation among regular starters, the players managers actually choose between.

- **Forecasts: clearly better.** Lower error than every comparator and the best ranking of regular starters within each week.
- **Captains: better than naive rules only.** The model beats the priciest attacker by +1.46 points a week and unadjusted form by +1.37. Against form scaled by fixtures (+0.43 (−0.81 to +1.62)) and the regression (+0.87 (−0.21 to +1.93)) the difference is within noise. The edge over the price rule comes almost entirely from 2024/25.
- **Behind the best managers.** Their consensus captain outscores the model's by 1.59 points a week, and their elevens beat its picks too. So the model fails the pre-set rule.
- **Robust.** Ten variants with inputs removed or settings changed, plus a block bootstrap, give the same verdict.

Why the best managers still win

They know things the model does not: team news, late injuries, penalty duty (Bonello et al., 2019). The comparison also flatters them: they are in the sample *because* their season went well, a survivorship effect (Brown et al., 1992).

Usage rate, explained

Basketball's usage rate is the share of a team's possessions a player ends while on the floor (Basketball-Reference, 2026; Oliver, 2004). A football version (Sincere FC, 2025a,b) counts shots plus every lost ball. With Opta data (Premier League, 2026),

$$\text{usage}_i = 100 \cdot \frac{\text{actions}_i \cdot (\text{team minutes}/11)}{\text{minutes}_i \cdot \text{team actions}}.$$

It is a revealing chart of who needs the ball and who makes the most of it. As a predictor, last season's usage cut forecast error by only +0.003 (+0.001 to +0.004) points. Captain and lineup choices did not change detectably.

One lesson for anyone judging FPL advice

Weekly captain scores are noisy: two captaincy rules' weekly difference has a standard deviation of about 5 points. Measuring a one-point-a-week edge to ± 1 takes about 96 gameweeks. Reliably detecting it takes about 196, five seasons. A good month proves very little.

Takeaways for managers

- Minutes first. Recent minutes and starts matter more than any other input group.
- Count fixtures. Much of a model's apparent edge over simple form disappears once form is scaled for double gameweeks.
- Judge advice over seasons, not weeks.

What happens next

From gameweek 7 of 2026/27, the model's captain is logged before every deadline beside the official expected-points pick and a price rule. Logs are frozen at the deadline and scored afterwards.

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